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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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Torture files reveal a Syria rife with horror

Aleppo intelligence site offers glimpse into wide abuses of Assad's regime

BY LOUISA LOVELUCK AND SALWAN GEORGES

ALEPPO, SYRIA — In some ways, the binders in the basement of Aleppo's general intelligence branch lay out what happened here in meticulous detail. They list every victim and every alleged crime. But they don't capture the fear; they don't mention the torture, or the smell.

There were buildings like this in every Syrian city: pillars of a security state so pervasive that it was not unusual for people to remark that even the walls had ears. Long before prisoners reached the country's notorious jails, they were surveilled and interrogated in their neighborhoods. The Assad dynasty's survival depended on it, and for five decades, the system worked.

The ruling family is gone now, having fled a Syrian rebel advance on the capital last week, but the files inside Aleppo's Branch 322 offer a glimpse of the abuses they commissioned. Paper files dating back to the earliest months of the 2011 uprising against the Syrian president, Bashar al-Assad, fill in the gaps of how the regime fought back. Branch 322 was one of hundreds

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HTS: Blinken says U.S. is in contact with new Islamist leaders. **A14**

After Assad's fall: Autocrats in region fear unrest at home. **A15**



KIM HONG-JI/REUTERS

S. Korea's Yoon is impeached

Constitutional Court will weigh charges against leader who declared martial law

BY MICHELLE YE HEE LEE IN SEOUL

People celebrate outside the National Assembly in Seoul after lawmakers voted to impeach President Yoon Suk Yeol, the second attempt to oust the South Korean leader.

side whether to uphold the impeachment charges, a process that could take up to six months. If the court decides the legislature's decision is constitutional, Yoon will be removed from office and a new presidential election will be held within 60 days.

Saturday's vote was the National Assembly's second attempt to oust Yoon. He survived the opposition parties' first impeachment effort on Dec. 7, after lawmakers from his conservative People Power Party boycotted the vote.

But Yoon's refusal to resign, and his defiantly stated belief that he

SEE SOUTH KOREA ON A13

D.C. middle school team learns to play NIL game

At John Hayden Johnson, a football powerhouse, success is complicated

BY MATT COHEN

Late in the summer of 2023, before the 60-odd middle-schoolers would go undefeated for the seventh straight regular season and win another D.C. championship — before they had even completed a practice — their coach took them to Chase Bank.

Mike Sharrieff likes to run his football program in a professional manner. He requires his players to maintain a 3.0 GPA, a full point higher than the D.C. school system's minimum for athletics eligibility. If they fall below his mark, they're required to attend

school on Saturday. Practice, study hall, bus trips to games and community service days are all part of this football machine Sharrieff has built at John Hayden Johnson Middle School in Southeast Washington.

But in the modern game, running a successful football program means teaching players how to deal with the name, image and likeness (NIL) deals that are reshaping the game — even among middle-schoolers. At least five of Johnson's players have NIL agreements as the arms race for talent extends deeper and deeper into the grassroots game.

The money that drives football doesn't end in college, where NIL deals have come to shape the game, or the NFL, where multimillion-dollar contracts are signed every week. Since the NCAA opened the door to

SEE NIL ON A8



MELINA MARA/THE WASHINGTON POST

A struggle to stay afloat

Day cares get little help in Idaho. This family-run center is buckling.

BY KARIN BRULLIARD IN NAPMA, IDAHO

Payday was coming, and the day care's bank account was dangerously low, so Krystal McFarlane again went outside to check TLC for Tots' black mailbox. She hoped to find the payment that one toddler's dad kept promising would arrive. She returned with empty hands and a sigh.

"It's the 15th and we still don't have it," McFarlane told her assistant over the tiny voices of children eating generic Cheerios at pint-size tables. She sat at a front desk piled with estimates for

painting the center's weathered exterior, a bill for the printer, a rent check that TLC was paying late for the first time in 16 years and a computer loaded with figures revealing the "hit after hit after hit" that McFarlane worried might soon force her to close.

Running the day care had never been easy or lucrative. Now the whole situation felt utterly broken.

The federal funds that helped businesses like TLC stay afloat during the pandemic — with grants and pay boosts — had expired in 2023, cut off early by Idaho's conservative legislature. But the staff still expected the higher pay, which at around \$14 an hour was not close to a living wage. Costs of insurance and supplies like plastic gloves and canned vegetables kept climbing. And parents were struggling even more to afford

SEE IDAHO ON A6

Krystal McFarlane of TLC For Tots in November. As her day care and the parents depending on it worry about the future, lawmakers in this conservative state say government shouldn't play a role.



HANNAH FOSLIEN FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Coach Mike Sharrieff has players with name, image and likeness deals. He teaches them the connection between money and sports.

METRO

A D.C. Council member called for the expulsion of Trayon White Sr.

SPORTS

Colorado two-way star Travis Hunter claims the Heisman Trophy.



BUSINESS

Hot Wheels sales are on fire, powered by adult collectors and nostalgia.

BOOK WORLD

Two of the greatest living cartoonists discuss their works — and their lives.



ARTS & STYLE

The cream of the crop in television, film, theater, art, games and music.

TRAVEL

Morocco's capital flies under tourists' radar. That's part of its appeal.

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Trump's plan on executive actions: See you in court

Incoming administration welcomes challenges to his unilateral moves

BY ISAAC ARNSDORF AND JEFF STEIN

Officials in the incoming Trump administration have an answer for anyone questioning the validity of several policies they plan to implement immediately and unilaterally: Go ahead and sue.

President-elect Donald Trump has long promised to take executive action to withhold birthright citizenship from people born in the United States to parents who are undocumented immigrants, but his advisers now see a court fight as a goal of that effort, rather than an obstacle.

Similarly, incoming budget officials have said they want to openly defy a 1974 law by refusing to spend money that Congress has authorized, forcing a lawsuit to test the Watergate-era statute's constitutionality. And aides involved in the transition said they'll plow ahead with reviving a policy from late in Trump's first

SEE TRUMP ON A10

The Sunday Take: Can a swiftly moving Trump fulfill his pledges? **A2**

Rubio's seat: DeSantis pressed to appoint Lara Trump to Senate. **A3**